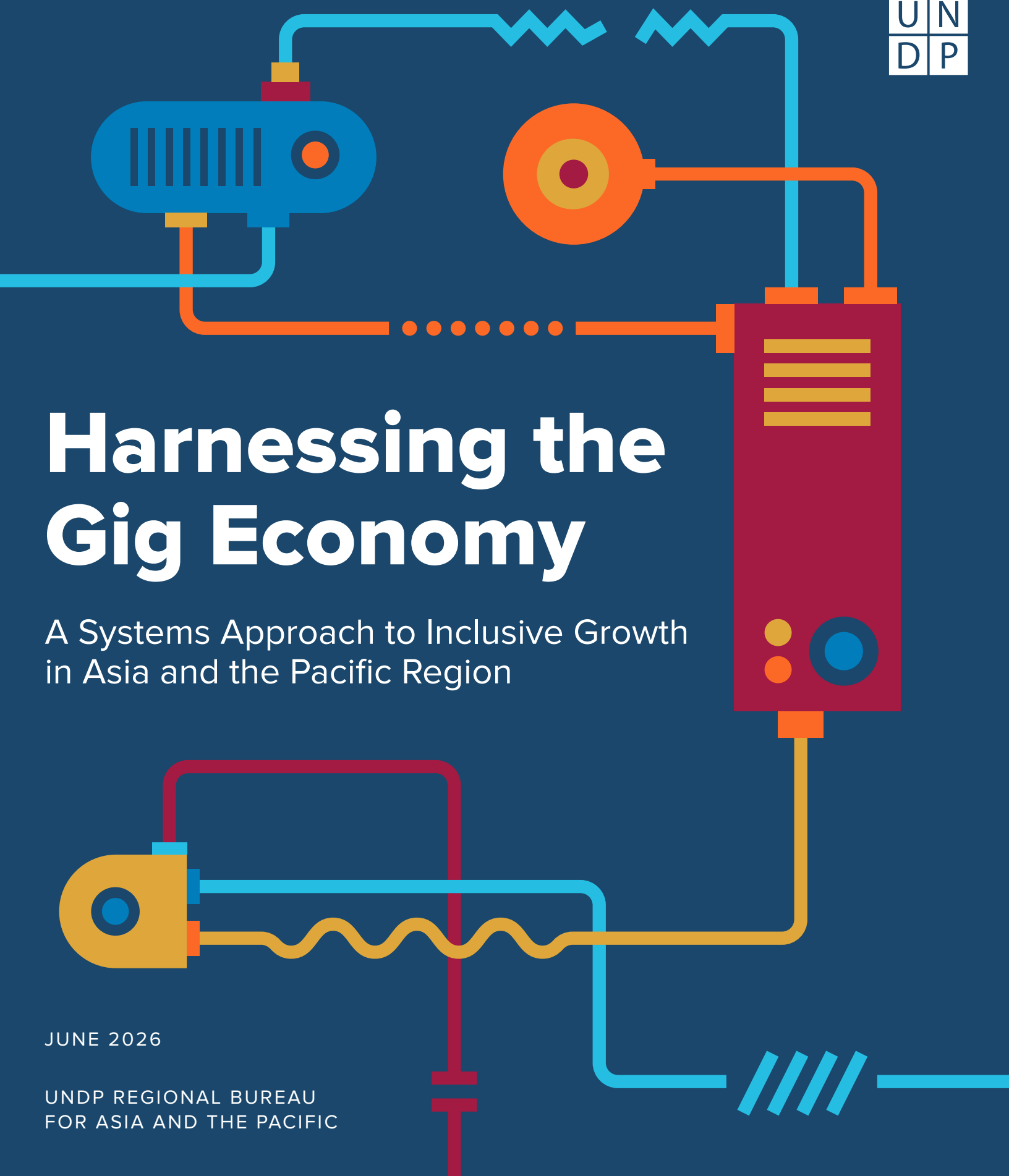
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Harnessing the Gig Economy

A Systems Approach to Inclusive Growth in Asia and the Pacific Region

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Harnessing the Gig Economy: A Systems Approach to Inclusive Growth in Asia and the Pacific Regions

The policy paper “Harnessing the Gig Economy: A Systems Approach to Inclusive Growth in Asia and the Pacific Regions” was prepared under the guidance of Kanni Wignaraja (UNDP Regional Director for Asia and the Pacific) and under the direction and substantive contribution of Smriti Aryal (Chief, Country Office Liaison and Coordination, UNDP Regional Bureau for Asia and the Pacific). The paper has been authored by Nazneen Ahmed (Policy Advisor). It was reviewed internally by Alexandru Oprunenco (Regional Innovation Advisor) and Devika Iyer (Regional SDG Integration Advisor), and externally by Dr. Sarayu Natarajan and her team at Aapti Foundation, India.

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Key messages

- Gig work is structural. It is now part of how the labour market functions and must be governed as such.
- Opportunity is real, but insecurity is widespread. Flexibility and income access often come with volatility, weak voice, and thin protections.
- Digital informality is the core risk. Platforms can replicate the vulnerabilities of informal work while scaling them faster.
- Protection gaps are the critical failure point. Social security and labour standards often do not cover multi-job, task-based livelihoods.
- Algorithmic governance needs accountability. Pricing, allocation, ratings, and deactivation systems should be transparent, contestable, and subject to oversight.
- Gig economy also suffers from inequality. Digital divides shape who benefits and who remains in low-value work.
- As platform work scales, so do fraud, fake job offers, identity theft, and exploitative intermediaries, making trust, verification, and digital safety part of the labour policy agenda.
- The future of gig work will be reshaped by big transitions. AI/automation, cross-border online work, and the green transition will change what gigs exist, who benefits, and what protections are needed.
- Effective governance is essential for a productive gig economy. The aim is to guide it towards decent and productive work through coherent governance that integrates labour policy, social protection, digital regulation, fiscal policy, and competition rules.

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1. Overview

The Asia-Pacific region is at the epicentre of the global gig economy boom that offers unprecedented flexibility and income to millions (WEF, 2025)[1]. The gig economy refers to a labour market characterised by short-term, flexible work arrangements, often facilitated by digital platforms (ILO, 2025).[2] Gig workers are now a non-negligible part of the global labour force, with about 154 million to 435 million people doing online gig jobs, which is around 4.4% to 12.5% of the total (Datta et al, 2023).[3] The number would be much higher if offline gig work were included. This policy paper speaks to both.

In China, over 200 million individuals, about 40% of the urban labour force, depend on various flexible work (The Economist, 2025)[4] Indonesia's gig workforce is estimated at between 430,000 and 2.3 million, comprising various types of gig workers (WEF, 2025). India is projected to have 23.5 million gig workers by 2029-30, making up 40% of the global freelance market. Bangladesh has over 650,000 online freelancers (The Daily Star, 2024)[5], one of the largest such pools in the world, and Pakistan, the Philippines, and Vietnam are also emerging hubs for online and offline gig work.

Across the Asia-Pacific region, significant demographic and economic shifts are reshaping labour markets and driving the growth of the gig economy. Many countries are experiencing a youth bulge, with large groups of young workers entering the job market while formal job creation remains slow (ILO, 2024).[6] This shortage of formal employment opportunities contributes to persistently high levels of informal work, making gig work an accessible alternative. Additionally, rapid urbanisation has increased the demand for platform-based services. A sweeping digital transformation, marked by the widespread use of smartphones and expanding internet access, supports the growth of the gig economy by enabling digital platforms to scale quickly. Furthermore, the COVID-19 pandemic accelerated the adoption and expansion of remote work.

However, this rapid rise in gig work also exposes workers to "digital informality": irregular earnings, economic instability, algorithmic control and a lack of protections. These challenges mirror long-standing issues in the Asia-Pacific's informal economy. The gig economy is not simply a new form of work- it is a complex system that is rapidly expanding due to structural labour market gaps, demographic change, digital transitions, and shocks. It is now a semi-permanent feature of regional labour markets that links with social protection, digital inclusion, gender equality, and sustainable development. Gig work is both a buffer against shocks and a driver of transformation, but one that requires deliberate governance to ensure equity and sustainability.

This paper provides a concise overview of key issues surrounding the gig economy and implications for countries in Asia and the Pacific. It argues that embedding the gig economy within broader systems of economic and governance reforms, social protection transformations, digital inclusion, and climate action can help ensure that gig work contributes to more inclusive and expanding labour markets, resilient livelihoods, and advances in human development.

[1] World Economic Forum (WEF). 2025. How Asia's booming gig economy is reshaping the future of work. 26 June. Available at: https://www.weforum.org/stories/2025/06/what-will-it-take-to-make-the-gig-economy-in-asia-fair-and-sustainable/ (accessed 22 September 2025).

[2] International Labour Organization (ILO). 2025. Exploring the gig economy: Challenges and opportunities. Self-guided resource.

[3] Datta, Namita, Chen Rong, Sunamika Singh, Clara Stinshoff, Nadina Iacob, Natnael Simachew Nigatu, Mpumelelo Nxumalo, and Luka Klimaviciute. 2023. Working Without Borders: The Promise and Peril of Online Gig Work. World Bank.

[4] The Economist. 2025. China's 200m gig workers are a warning for the world: What a giant precarious workforce reveals about the future of jobs. Article published 18 September 2025.

[5] The Daily Star, 2024. Bangladesh's reputation as a freelancing powerhouse is on the line, Article published on 28 May, 2024.

[6] International Labour Organization (ILO). 2024. Global Employment Trends for Youth 2024: Asia and the Pacific. Brief. August 2024.

2. Gig Economy/Gig work: Definition

Originally coined in 1915 and now widely associated with platform-based labour, “Gig Work” refers to short-term, flexible, task-specific employment arrangements that deviate from the conventional parameters of standard employment. When these types of work arrangements become prevalent in an economy, it is referred to as a “Gig Economy.” Instead of traditional open-ended employment contracts, gig work involves on-demand tasks or projects completed for payment on a per-task or per-service basis. This model spans a wide array of sectors and job types, from driving for a ride-hailing app or delivering food to freelancing online as a graphic designer or coder.

Broadly, gig work falls into two categories. At one end of the spectrum are the location-based gigs that require physical presence (e.g. rideshare driving, delivery couriers, domestic services, care workers, warehouse gig workers). At the other end of the spectrum are the online “cloud” gigs that can be done remotely via the internet (e.g. digital freelancing in design, programming, writing, data entry, etc.). What unites these diverse gigs is their reliance on apps and digital platforms to connect workers with customers, handle payments, and, often, algorithmically manage the work. Workers need access to the internet and to internet-enabled devices, as well as some level of digital literacy. The platforms utilise algorithms to connect workers with tasks, create an environment for interactions between supply and demand, and set guidelines for the work being performed.

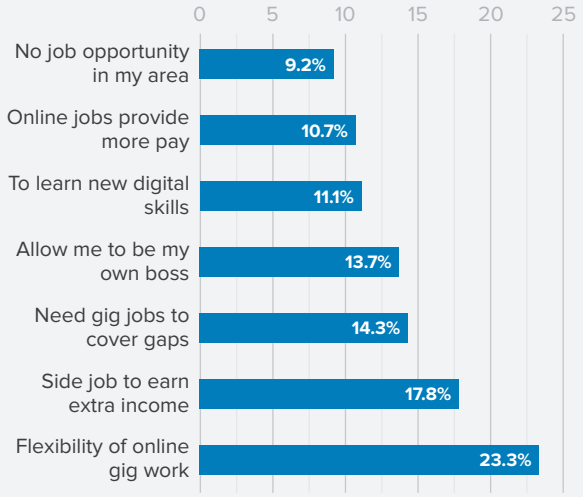
Gig opportunities vary significantly by country and region, depending on internet access, regulations in force, economic factors and level of skills specialisation. Gig work also intersects with traditional employment, as many workers combine both. For example, a nurse could offer telehealth consultations outside regular shifts; a full-time IT professional might take on freelance projects on weekends; a cook might sell homemade meals or host virtual cooking classes.

Gig workers are typically classified as self-employed or independent contractors, meaning they usually lack access to minimum wages, paid leave, health insurance, or pension plans that formal employees enjoy (ILO, 2025). Rather than receiving a regular pay check, gig workers are paid after completing a series of tasks or an entire project. This would often require having some advanced income or assets to begin the ‘gig’ journey.

3. The Structural Transformation of Work and the Evolution of the Gig Economy

The rise of gig work is no longer a fleeting or marginal trend. The preferences of businesses and consumers, as well as broader structural shifts in the economy, including growth in the manufacturing and services sectors, rapid urbanisation, large-scale shocks, and demographic shifts in the region, have consolidated its position and practice. Technological advancements have played a pivotal role in facilitating this evolution. Worker motivation to work on digital labour platforms varies across platform types and by gender (ILO, 2021)[7]. Datta et al. (2023) has identified flexibility, additional income opportunities, and addressing the livelihood income gap as key reasons for the growing adoption of gig work (Figure 1).

Figure 1: Motivation to engage in online gig work (% share of online gig workers)



Source: Datta et al. (2023).

Demographic and labour market shifts

In Asia and the Pacific, structural employment gaps, rapid labour force growth, particularly among youth, outpace formal job creation. Many countries face a youth bulge, with millions entering the workforce each year, yet formal employment opportunities remain scarce or inaccessible. At the same time, a large share of the region's workforce has long operated in informal settings with limited job security, wages, or protections. In this context, gig work, whether through ride-sharing, delivery services, or online freelancing, offers an accessible income stream. For many, platform-based work is not a choice but a necessity in such a constrained labour market.

Beyond necessity, a significant number of people are also attracted by the flexibility and independence that gig work promises. Students, caregivers, and others who need a flexible work schedule find gig opportunities appealing because they can choose when and how much to work. On freelance platforms, the primary motivator seems to be the desire for job flexibility or to work from home, while on microtask platforms, supplementing income is key. A survey of 1,500 Malaysian gig workers found that flexibility, accessibility, and the opportunity to earn supplementary income were the three primary reasons individuals joined gig work. The need for flexibility is especially significant for women in both developing and developed countries, as in most cases, they are the primary caregivers in the family and must balance paid work with family responsibilities.

Digital and urban transitions

An essential underlying driver of gig economy expansion is the instrumental advancement in technology and the dramatic improvement in digital infrastructure, both public and private. The proliferation of affordable smartphones, the

[7] International Labour Organization (ILO). 2021. World Employment and Social Outlook 2021: The role of digital labour platforms in transforming the world of work. Report.

enhancement of 4G/5G mobile networks, and the development of secure digital payment systems have collectively enabled the scalability of gig platform models. Individuals are increasingly turning to freelancing or launching micro-businesses on digital platforms, especially where formal employment or entrepreneurship options remain limited. Digital platforms blur the line between self-employment and wage work, offering more start-up accessibility than establishing a formal business. This progress has been greatly facilitated by government investments in digital public infrastructure (DPI) and related skills development, with India, the Republic of Korea, and Singapore among regional frontrunners building strong DPI stacks that are opening vast new opportunities for access to markets, services, and livelihoods.

Simultaneously, the rapid urbanisation in Asia and the Pacific has led to the emergence of a tech-savvy middle class with evolving service expectations. Urban consumers are driving a cultural shift towards convenience, speed, and affordability- demanding services like ride-hailing, food delivery, and home cleaning. This consumer pull has fuelled the proliferation of app-based services. Megacities like Jakarta, Bangkok, Manila, and Ho Chi Minh City now host millions of users of platforms like Grab, Gojek, Foodpanda, etc., whose popularity in turn generates more gig work opportunities. The more consumers use these services, the more work is generated for gig workers, creating a self-reinforcing cycle of demand. However, studies have also shown that the rapid platformisation of urban services has actively reshaped, and in some cases weakened, existing labour and transport infrastructures (ILO, 2021). In some areas, the erosion of traditional taxi services and the inadequacy or unreliability of public transport have steered consumers towards more ride-hailing applications. In such contexts, consumers often turn to platforms not solely out of preference but due to the absence of viable alternatives.

On the supply side, businesses, ranging from micro-entrepreneurs to large firms, are embracing the gig model for its scalability, cost-efficiency, and workforce flexibility. Digital platforms enable employers to hire talent on demand, avoiding long-term contracts or fixed payrolls. This model is particularly attractive for startups and small businesses, while larger corporations use online freelancing platforms to outsource specialised tasks.

Shock accelerators

The COVID-19 pandemic catalysed platform adoption. During the lockdown, many formal jobs disappeared overnight, while demand for delivery, logistics, and remote digital services surged, which embedded gig work more deeply in national labour markets. For instance, demand for grocery and medicine delivery via gig couriers surged across Asian cities during lockdowns. Also, businesses, having gone remote, became more open to hiring freelancers online. For some businesses, the motivation for hiring freelancers was not only for flexibility, but also to externalise costs by sourcing labour from lower-cost markets in Asia and the Pacific, particularly in creative, translation, data, and content-moderation work. The COVID-19 period effectively normalised gig work as a larger part of labour market dynamics and introduced new users (both workers and customers) to these platforms. As economies reopened, gig work had cemented a larger role and was advancing rapidly in most countries in the region especially in countries such as India and the Philippines, where global demand for remote services has historically intersected with large, skilled, and cost-competitive labour pools (Datta et al, 2023).

However, post-shock trajectories have been uneven: while some workers have transitioned back into formal employment, many have remained in gig work due to persistent shortages of quality jobs or the flexibility it offers, often continuing to face income volatility and limited protections (ILO, 2021). These demographic, technological, and shock-related drivers explain why gig work has become a structural feature of labour markets rather than a temporary phenomenon, underscoring the need for proactive policies that integrate gig work into social protection systems, skills strategies, and governance frameworks rather than treating it as a marginal or informal activity.

4. Interconnected Inequalities

While the gig economy has offered job opportunities, it has exposed workers to multiple vulnerabilities and challenges, many of which echo broader socio-economic issues such as inequalities across gender, geography, and socio-economic status. This section addresses key challenges, while section 6 explores policy considerations to leverage gig economy development for human development.

Precarity and informality

Gig workers often face precarious conditions such as low and volatile earnings, long and irregular hours, and limited safety and social protections. They are typically excluded from formal labour regulations. The nature and degree of precarity differ across digital labour platforms. Location-based workers, such as ride-hailing drivers and delivery couriers, are more exposed to physical risks, long and unpredictable hours, algorithmic management, and must often cover work-related costs like fuel and maintenance. In contrast, online web-based workers, including freelancers and microworkers, face less physical risk but experience significant income insecurity due to global competition, unpaid waiting time, opaque task allocation, and limited bargaining power.

Most gig workers are classified as self-employed contractors, which means they lack access to health insurance, injury compensation, pensions, or grievance mechanisms. NITI Aayog (2022)[8] highlights that the vast majority of gig and platform workers in India remain excluded from formal social security coverage under current schemes, leaving them economically vulnerable in case of work-related accidents or illness.

Income volatility and pay gaps

Gig workers are typically paid per task or per delivery, with no guaranteed minimum wage. Demand fluctuations, intense competition, and platform fees lead to highly irregular earnings. ILO (2021) noted that the overwhelming majority of workers on location-based platforms and about one-third of the workers on online web-based platforms stated that platform work was their primary source of income, while many of them often struggle to find sufficient, well-paid work to earn a decent income. Because the volume of tasks or jobs is uncertain and sometimes sporadic, workers experience substantial fluctuations in their earnings. Worker earnings on online platforms vary significantly, with about half earning under US$2 per hour. Typical hourly rates range from US$3.3 on microtask platforms to US$7.6 on freelance platforms, and workers in developing countries earn 60% less than those in developed nations. Factors affecting earnings include time spent on unpaid tasks, competition from excess labour supply, high commission fees, and non-payment due to work rejection (ILO, 2021). Studies show gender pay gaps among both online and location-based platform workers (such as Adams and Berg (2017)[9], ILO (2021), Churchill (2023)[10]. These gaps do not stem from different pay rates but from persistent gendered inequalities. Women are concentrated in lower-paid care, administrative, and microwork tasks, while men dominate higher-paid delivery and driving roles. In ride-sharing, disparities are explained by experience, location choices, and driving speed rather than discrimination (Cook et al., 2018)[11].

Digital Divide

Access to the internet and digital tools is fundamental for participating in the gig economy. Existing digital divides-urban vs. rural, wealthy vs. poor, and gender disparities create inequities in access. In many rural areas, broadband connectivity is limited or costly, and smartphone ownership is not universal. Additionally, a lack of digital literacy or English skills restricts competition on global freelancing platforms. The skills mismatch is clear, as demand for skilled

[8] NITI Aayog. 2022. India's Booming Gig and Platform Economy: Perspectives and Recommendations on the Future of Work. Policy brief. June 2022. Government of India.

[9] Adams, Abi, and Janine Marie Berg. 2017. When Home Affects Pay: An Analysis of the Gender Pay Gap Among Crowdworkers. SSRN Electronic Journal. Available at: ResearchGate.

[10] Churchill, Brendan. 2023. The gender pay platform gap during the COVID-19 pandemic and the role of platform gender segregation in Australia. New Technology, Work and Employment, 39(1). Available at: ResearchGate.

[11] Cook, Cody, Rebecca Diamond, Jonathan Hall, John A. List, and Paul Oyer. 2018. The Gender Earnings Gap in the Gig Economy: Evidence from over a Million Rideshare Drivers. NBER Working Paper 24732. National Bureau of Economic Research.

gigs (like coding and digital marketing) is high, while many entering the gig economy have only a basic education and end up in low-skill, low-pay jobs. And this could grow much wider as AI advances. Women face additional constraints related to access, safety, and care responsibilities, shaping both their entry into gig work and the types of opportunities available to them.

Algorithmic asymmetry

Gig workers are managed not by human supervisors, but by algorithms and data-driven systems embedded in the apps. These algorithms assign tasks, set prices, evaluate performance (via ratings), and can even deactivate workers from the platform. This algorithmic control extends to surveillance and performance pressure, nudging workers to work faster or longer. This can create a constant pressure to be available and productive. The process is typically opaque; workers often do not know how decisions are made or how to contest them. This creates a stark power imbalance between individual gig workers and the platform companies. Workers may be penalised or removed due to an algorithmic decision (for instance, automated account suspension for falling below a rating threshold) with little recourse or human review. Lack of transparency and accountability in these systems remains a significant challenge.

5. Emerging Systemic Forces

Gig work intersects with megatrends related to artificial intelligence (AI), climate change, the green transition, and global digital integration, which require anticipatory governance and resilience planning.

AI and automation

AI technologies have been evolving both as complements and competitors to gig workers. AI can generate new gig opportunities, such as increased demand for data labelling, AI model training, and "prompt engineering," as well as boosting productivity for skilled freelancers who use AI tools. However, many of these new opportunities in the AI supply chain are often precarious, characterised by low wages, a lack of employment benefits, and fragmented working conditions. These conditions can even expose workers to psychological harm, for example, from labelling toxic or traumatic content (Canadian Affairs, 2025).[12]

At the same time, some platform companies are actively seeking to mitigate vulnerabilities by leveraging platform data and partnerships to support workers' development, such as skill acquisition and worker representation. For example, Grab Singapore has introduced initiatives such as GrabBenefits 2.0 and formal recognition of worker associations under the Platform Workers Act, offering subsidised healthcare, upskilling opportunities, and structured dialogue on work conditions to improve worker welfare (GRAB, 2025).[13]

The widespread concern regarding the AI revolution is that it may automate many tasks currently performed by gig workers, potentially reducing demand for human labour in certain areas. For example, AI writing assistants can perform basic content writing or translation gigs; algorithms can code increasingly sophisticated programs, reducing demand for entry-level coders; self-driving technology could displace ride-share drivers. The net impact of AI is thus complex. UNDP (2025)[14] notes that online gig workers in Asia and the Pacific face a greater risk of job displacement from AI than location-based gig workers providing in-person services. This report highlights two key factors that influence AI's impact on gig work. First, when AI can match or exceed human skills, it increases the risk of worker displacement. However, if AI enhances human abilities, it can boost productivity. Second, tasks that require contextual understanding or experiential judgment are less likely to be automated, with AI serving mainly as a support tool.

Green transition

The global movement towards a green economy and climate action is a significant trend that may impact gig work. As countries invest in renewable energy, circular economy initiatives, and climate-resilient infrastructure, new jobs are expected to emerge, many of which will take the form of gigs or short-term contracts. For instance, renewable energy companies might hire on-demand technicians to install solar panels in remote communities.[15] Additionally, the growth of waste management and recycling startups may utilise gig workers for tasks such as waste collection and sorting, thereby contributing to a circular economy. The gig workforce could play a crucial role in implementing climate solutions at the grassroots level (such as community solar maintenance, urban gardening, etc.). However, for green gig work to contribute meaningfully to human development, such roles must move beyond low-paid and intermittent tasks. In practice, this requires clearer skill pathways, predictable demand, and minimum standards around pay, safety, and working conditions, as well as access to training, equipment, and social protection. At the same time, growing demand for rapid, on-demand services risks driving higher emissions, congestion, and energy use. Reducing this footprint requires integrating green-transition priorities directly into platform regulation and urban mobility policy.

[12] Canadian Affairs. 2025. The gruelling, low-paid human work behind generative AI curtain. 17 October. Available at: https://www.canadianaffairs.news/2025/10/17/the-gruelling-low-paid-human-work-behind-generative-ai-curtain/ (accessed 25 October 2025).

[13] Grab. 2025. Grab officially recognises NDCA and NPHVA to represent platform workers. Available at: https://www.grab.com/sg/press/others/grab-officially-recognises-ndca-and-nphva-to-represent-platform-workers/ (accessed 25 October 2025).

[14] UNDP, 2025: The Next Great Divergence: Why AI May Widen Inequality Between Countries, Regional Bureau for Asia and the Pacific, UNDP.

[15] Green World Renewable Energy. n.d. How the gig economy is powering the growth of renewable energy projects. Available at: https://www.green-world-energy.com/blog/how-the-gig-economy-is-powering-the-growth-of-renewable-energy-projects.

Global and transboundary economic and digital integration

The global reach of digital platforms has transformed the gig economy into an international, regional and cross-border opportunity. Freelancing platforms (such as Upwork, Freelancer, Fiverr) connect workers in developing Asia with international clients, enabling income generation beyond local wage constraints. Workers benefit from tapping into higher-paying global markets, while firms in developed countries leverage cost-effective talent. According to the Datta et al. (2023), low- and middle-income countries now account for 40% of global traffic to online gig platforms, highlighting the growing integration of developing countries into global digital labour markets while the gig workers on the global platforms may have relatively more autonomy in choosing projects and setting rates compared to workers on local, location-based platforms (like ride-share), precarity is universal across the gig economy, and online platforms are fundamentally similar in their reliance on algorithmic control using opaque algorithmic rating and ranking systems that lack transparency for workers. The global integration may intensify competition among workers across borders, particularly in lower-skilled segments, where labour oversupply can put downward pressure on prices and earnings. These dynamics contribute to income volatility, weakened bargaining power, and persistent precarity, underscoring the transboundary governance challenges associated with platform-mediated work.

Emerging political dynamics of gig work

Across the region, gig workers are increasingly making their voices heard. In countries like Indonesia, Malaysia, and Thailand, delivery riders and ride-hailing drivers have demonstrated their ability to mobilise rapidly through social media and messaging platforms, staging large-scale protests over wages, commission structures, and social protections (CNA, 2025).[16] This activism has evolved into political participation, with some gig workers winning seats on local councils in Indonesia. The growing visibility and organisation of gig workers signal a shift from fragmented labour activism to a systemic force influencing policy debates and electoral strategies, particularly as politicians recognise their numbers and potential as a strategic voter bloc.

Risks of scam platforms

While platform-based gig work has unlocked new avenues for flexible employment and income generation across Asia and the Pacific, it is important to recognise that not all platform-mediated activities align with the principles or protections of the legitimate gig economy. The emergence of scam centres and illegal digital operations, where individuals are coerced or deceived into fraudulent online work, represents a parallel, illicit ecosystem that exploits the same technological infrastructure but operates outside the bounds of legal and ethical labour markets. Unlike mainstream gig platforms, which connect workers to legitimate tasks and clients, these scam platforms are orchestrated by criminal syndicates and often involve trafficking, forced labour, and cybercrime. And such scam platforms have grown big in parts of the Asia-Pacific region (OHCHR, 2023[17], UNODC, 2024, 2025)[18] [19]. This distinction underscores the need for robust governance, cross-border regulatory cooperation, and vigilant monitoring to ensure that platform-based job opportunities remain a force for inclusive development, rather than a vector for exploitation.

[16] Channel News Asia. 2025. From protests to politics: How gig workers are reshaping Southeast Asia's power balance. Available at: https://www.channelnewsasia.com/asia/indonesia-delivery-riders-grab-gojek-south-east-asia-malaysia-thailand-protests-political-force-5368301 (accessed 10 December 2025).

[17] Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR). 2023. Online Scam Operations and Trafficking into Forced Criminality in Southeast Asia: Recommendations for a Human Rights Response. United Nations.

[18] United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC). 2024. Transnational Organized Crime and the Convergence of Cyber-Enabled Fraud, Underground Banking and Technological Innovation in Southeast Asia: A Shifting Threat Landscape. United Nations.

[19] United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC). 2025. Inflection Point: Global Implications of Scam Centres, Underground Banking and Illicit Online Marketplaces in Southeast Asia. United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime.

6. Gig Economy as a Force for Advancing Human Development: Some Policy Considerations

Harnessing gig work to advance and accelerate human development requires embedding it within broader development policy and strategies for inclusion, resilience, and improved productivity.

a) **Livelihood diversification:** The gig economy can be prepped to expand during periods of formal economic downturn to act as a livelihood buffer during economic shocks, unemployment or personal transitions. These periods, such as during pandemics or extended disasters, could be anticipated, and the necessary adjustments to facilitate the gig economy could be triggered as needed. Gig platforms match supply and demand in real time, which is particularly beneficial for reaching previously underserved markets. For instance, ride-sharing apps have increased mobility options in cities lacking reliable public transport. Food and e-commerce delivery platforms have connected small restaurants and shop owners to broader customer bases. In rural areas, some platforms are aggregating farmers or craftsmen to sell products online, overcoming traditional market access barriers. These are planned and targeted strategy options to consider.

b) **Skills and entrepreneurship:** The gig economy can motivate individuals to develop new skills, and this could be incentivised. Online gig work, in particular, exposes workers to global standards and helps improve their digital literacy, communication abilities, and entrepreneurial skills. Additionally, the gig economy lowers the barriers to entrepreneurship; for example, an artisan can begin selling crafts on an online marketplace without needing significant upfront capital, with the possibility of growing into a larger business over time.

Realising these gains at scale, however, depends on addressing underlying digital divides. Expanding access to digital infrastructure, affordable devices, and relevant skills is critical for meaningful participation in the digital gig economy. Investments in Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI), including interoperable digital identification systems, secure digital payments, and data-sharing frameworks, can create the foundational conditions for gig workers to access platforms, financial services, and public programmes. Yet infrastructure alone is insufficient. Targeted digital skills development, particularly for women, youth, rural communities, and workers transitioning from informal sectors, is essential to ensure equitable participation in higher-value digital work. In many contexts, affordability remains a primary barrier; therefore, policies promoting low-cost smartphones, subsidised data packages, and community digital access points can significantly expand opportunities. Together, these measures ensure that digital gig work is not limited to those with existing advantages but becomes a viable pathway for a broader and more diverse labour force. For governments, investing in DPI, skills, and affordability provides a practical route to reducing structural digital inequalities while expanding access to emerging digital labour markets.

c) **Flexibility and inclusion:** The flexibility inherent in gig work supports inclusion for caregivers, persons with disabilities, and those in remote communities by enabling work from home or on one's own schedule. To translate this flexibility into equitable outcomes, however, gender-responsive design and policy measures should be embedded within both platform architecture and regulatory frameworks.

Women's gig work outcomes are shaped by mobility restrictions, safety concerns, and unequal care burdens.

Therefore, gender-responsive design standards must be embedded within the platform and policy architecture. Safety protocols, such as verified customer IDs, in-app emergency features, and safe commuting support, can expand women's participation in location-based gigs. Beyond safety, policy innovations like childcare credits, flexible scheduling guarantees, and compensated downtime can address the disproportionate care responsibilities that often push women into lower-paid microwork. Platform design standards that counter gender segmentation, for example, by highlighting women's profiles in higher-paying project categories or reducing reliance on biased rating systems, can also expand women's access to skilled freelance work.

d) Addressing income volatility and pay gaps: This requires strengthening the enabling environment that allows gig workers to achieve more stable and predictable earnings without sacrificing flexibility. Solutions such as portable benefits and minimum pay floors (Annex-1) demonstrate viable pathways to do so. Portable benefits systems, where contributions accrue in an individual worker account regardless of the platform they engage with, help smooth the impact of fluctuating earnings by ensuring continued access to health insurance, pensions, and injury protection even during periods of low demand. Minimum pay floors establish a baseline remuneration, reducing pressure from competition and opaque pricing structures on many platforms. Together, these measures can shift gig work from a high-risk, high-volatility livelihood strategy toward a more reliable source of income.

e) Addressing regulatory ambiguity and ensuring social protection: In most countries, gig workers are neither classified as employees nor adequately protected as self-employed (ILO, ISSA and OECD, 2023[20] World Bank, 2024)[21]. The regulatory vacuum has created ambiguity for all parties: workers, platforms, and governments. This uncertainty hinders fair labour practices and social protections (ILO, 2021). Such governance gap is a concern not just for worker welfare but also for fostering fair competition in society and for fiscal considerations. For example, if gig companies are not paying into social security or abiding by labour standards that traditional companies must, it creates an uneven playing field. It also means governments might be losing out on taxes that could support social protection systems. Clarifying worker classification and extending minimum protections would reduce precarity, improve income security, and enable gig work to function as a stable complement to formal employment rather than a last-resort livelihood option.

In recent years, there have been examples of advancement in the regulatory landscape in some countries of the Asia-Pacific region. Before the Platform Workers Act 2024 (effective 1 January 2025), gig workers in Singapore were traditionally viewed as self-employed, a status that made them ineligible for mandatory Central Provident Fund (CPF) contributions (Choiruzzad et al, 2025).[22] This exclusion deprived them of a vital systemic safety net for retirement, housing, and healthcare. The Platform Workers Act 2024 requires platform operators to make CPF contributions, provide financial compensation for work-related injuries, and establish a legal framework for worker representation (Lesmana and Samudra, 2025).[23] In September 2025, Malaysia's Parliament passed the Gig Workers Bill 2025, which formally recognises gig workers as a distinct labour category (Malay mail, 2025).[24] The bill provides legal protections, including dispute resolution, income standards, and social security coverage. In Thailand, a draft bill for the ride-share drivers has been proposed (but not passed).[25] Some gig roles are undergoing formalisation and professionalisation. For example, China recently introduced new regulations requiring influencers to demonstrate expertise before monetising content on medicine, law, finance, education, etc. (Bajarin, Tim, 2025).[26]

The lack of formal recognition makes it hard to collect data and integrate gig work into national accounts and employment statistics. India's Social Security Code (2020) formally

[20] International Labour Organization (ILO), International Social Security Association (ISSA), and Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD). 2023. Providing adequate and sustainable social protection for workers in the gig and platform economy. Technical paper prepared for the G20 Employment Working Group. Geneva: ILO.

[21] World Bank. 2024. The gig economy and the future of work: Global trends and policy directions for non-standard forms of employment. Social Protection & Jobs Global Practice. Washington, DC: World Bank.

[22] Choiruzzad, S. A. B., M. H. F. Sidiq, and Herawati. 2025. Gig Economy, Rural Urban Mobility, and Poverty in the Post-COVID-19 Era. ASEAN Socio-Cultural Community Trend Report No. 19. Jakarta: ASEAN Secretariat.

[23] Lesmana, S. J., and M. M. Samudra. 2025. Legal Protection of Gig Economy Workers: A Comparative Study in Indonesia, Malaysia, and Singapore. SASI, 31(3), 201-218.

[24] Malay Mail. 2025. They will finally receive protection: Dewan Negara passes landmark Gig Workers Bill. 10 September. Available at: https://www.malaymail.com/news/malaysia/2025/09/10/they-will-finally-receive-protection-dewan-negara-passes-landmark-gig-workers-bill/190589 (accessed 12 December 2025).

[25] Techasupatkul, Kawalee. n.d. Thailand's Independent Workers Protection Act (Draft): Protection for Ride-Hailing Riders. Available at: https://www.lawplusltd.com/wp-content/uploads/kalins-pdf/singles/kawalee-techasupatkul-50.pdf (accessed 12 December 2025).

[26] Bajarin, Tim. 2025. China's credentialing crackdown: A reset for the influencer economy. Forbes. 13 November. Available at: https://www.forbes.com/sites/timbajarin/2025/11/13/chinas-credentialing-crackdown-a-reset-for-the-influencer-economy/ (accessed 12 December 2025).

recognised gig and platform workers as a separate category, a conceptual breakthrough.[27] At the sub-national level, Rajasthan's Platform-Based Gig Workers (Registration and Welfare) Act (2023) established a Welfare Board and a transaction-based welfare fund, both financed by platforms.[28] Similarly, the Karnataka Platform-Based Gig Workers (Social Security and Welfare) Bill (2025) has established a Welfare Board and a fund financed through a transaction-based welfare fee (1-5% of payout) levied on aggregators for every gig transaction.[29] Indonesia is exploring the possibilities of including gig workers in formal labour protections. These include social security enrolment, working-hour limits, and rest-period guarantees (ILO, 2023).[30] China has introduced a series of national guidelines to improve protections for gig workers, particularly in ride-hailing and delivery services.[31] Advancements in regulations across various countries offer valuable lessons for countries that still lag in developing or adapting regulatory frameworks to account for the realities of the gig economy.

f) Establishing Accountable Digital Governance: Addressing the challenges arising from algorithmic asymmetry requires establishing transparency and accountability mechanisms that give gig workers greater clarity and agency over how their work is managed. Governance oversight should therefore extend to platform algorithms, data systems, and reporting practices. Measures such as algorithmic audit requirements, through disclosure of pricing and ranking logic, independent assessments, or standardised fairness metrics, can help rebalance power between platforms and workers. Clear channels for human review of automated decisions, combined with transparency on commission structures and dynamic pricing, further strengthen worker protections.

For governments, embedding algorithmic transparency obligations within platform regulation is a critical step in safeguarding worker rights in increasingly data-driven labour markets. Moreover, workers' data privacy should be protected while ensuring that platform-generated data can be leveraged for collective worker benefits and regulatory oversight. At the same time, the crackdown on the illegal gig economy must continue aggressively. Illegal 'gig scams ', as currently seen in Myanmar, Cambodia and elsewhere, must be globally, regionally and nationally monitored and shut down. Governments can go beyond merely overseeing regulations and actively reshape the market structures for gig work. For instance, in India, there is an emerging government-backed initiative called Bharat Taxi, which is a zero-commission platform cooperative designed to reduce the exploitation of drivers by private aggregators (Scholz, 2025).[32] The results of this initiative are still to be seen; however, it illustrates how governments can influence the market while investing in DPI and guiding AI standards to rebalance power between tech giants and local economies, aligning digital transformation with social protection and decent work.

g) Strengthening Fiscal Sustainability in the Gig Economy: Ensuring fiscal sustainability in the gig economy requires updating revenue frameworks to reflect the realities of cross-border, platform-mediated work. As more income flows through global digital platforms, governments need mechanisms, such as basic platform reporting requirements or simplified withholding rules, to capture taxes on earnings generated domestically but paid from abroad. Misclassification of gig workers as independent contractors also erodes fiscal space by reducing employer contributions to social security and related labour taxes. Introducing clearer employment categories or hybrid statuses, alongside proportional platform contributions, can help rebalance this burden and strengthen the financing of national welfare systems. Earmarked digital levies, applied as small per-transaction fees, offer a practical way for platforms to support the public systems that underpin their operations. When directed to portable benefits funds or worker welfare mechanisms, these levies provide predictable financing without undermining flexibility. Modernising these fiscal tools will help governments create a fairer playing field, protect revenue sources, and enable more resilient social protection for gig workers.

These system-level policy frameworks set the stage for collective action. In the next and concluding chapter, the paper will elaborate on how Asia-Pacific's stakeholders can translate this framework into concrete steps to harness the gig economy for inclusive growth.

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[27] Press Information Bureau, Government of India. n.d. Available at: https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleaseIframePage.aspx?PRID=2078528 (accessed 12 December 2025).

[28] Government of Rajasthan. 2023. Act No. 29 of 2023 (Rajasthan). Available at: https://prsindia.org/files/bills_acts/acts_states/rajasthan/2023/Act29of-2023Rajasthan.pdf (accessed 12 December 2025).

[29] Government of Karnataka. n.d. Bill No. 31E. Available at: https://kla.kar.nic.in/council/house/bills/156/31E.pdf (accessed 12 December 2025).

[30] International Labour Organization (ILO). 2023. World Employment and Social Outlook: The Value of Essential Work.

[31] Business & Human Rights Resource Centre. n.d. China introduces new guidelines for online platforms to ensure minimum wage, breaks, and rights protection for gig workers. Available at: https://www.business-humanrights.org/en/latest-news/china-introduces-new-guidelines-for-online-platforms-to-ensure-minimum-wage-breaks-and-rights-protection-for-gig-workers/ (accessed 12 December 2025).

[32] Scholz. 2025. India launches Bharat Taxi, a national platform co-op. Platform Cooperativism Consortium. Available at: https://platform.coop/blog/india-launches-bharat-taxi-a-national-platform-co-op/ (accessed 12 December 2025).

7. From Policy Considerations to Strategic Support to the Gig Economy

The gig economy is highly heterogeneous. Effective policy responses, therefore, should be tailored to different segments of gig work and the risks and opportunities they face. Because gig work cuts across labour markets, social protection, digital governance, climate action, and public finance, it requires coordination across sectoral ministries and central economic institutions, as well as sustained engagement with development partners, platforms, gig workers' organisations, and the private sector. Regional cooperation and peer learning can also help countries share lessons, align standards where appropriate, and address cross-border dimensions of platform-mediated work.

From a systems perspective, the gig economy is not a standalone labour-market issue but sits within a web of interconnected systems. As analysed above, it intersects with labour market informality and social protection gaps, reflecting the challenges faced by workers who lack stable employment and adequate safety nets. The development and accessibility of digital infrastructure and literacy are crucial, as divides in these areas can limit participation and perpetuate inequality. Gender inequality and the dynamics of the care economy further shape who can access gig work and under what conditions, often disadvantaging women and caregivers. Governance, fiscal systems, and regulatory frameworks play a pivotal role in defining the rights, protections, and fiscal sustainability of gig work. Finally, climate and technological transitions influence the evolution of gig opportunities, necessitating adaptive policies aligned with broader sustainability and innovation goals. Together, these interconnected systems highlight the need for holistic, integrated approaches to policy and practice in the gig economy. The strategic areas below translate this systems lens into practical entry points.[33]

Inclusive Growth

Gig work can expand income opportunities and diversify livelihoods, but only if structural barriers, such as unequal access to technology, education, skills, and fair wages, are systematically addressed. At the country level, inclusive growth strategies can treat gig work as part of economic transformation rather than a marginal labour-market phenomenon. Priority actions include investing in affordable connectivity and digital public infrastructure; strengthening market-relevant digital and AI literacy; and building pathways from low-return activity into higher-value work through training, certification, and recognition of prior learning. In online gig segments, countries need to focus on retaining more value locally by improving contract transparency, supporting fairer market access mechanisms, and strengthening small-firm upgrading and export readiness where appropriate. At the regional level, cooperation can reduce friction and expand market access through interoperable digital payments, mutual learning on digital credentials, and workable dispute-resolution models suited to platform contracting. From a development assistance perspective, international technical partners and development actors can support evidence-based programme design and pilot evaluation. They can also support the convening of skills institutions, labour authorities, and platform stakeholders to accelerate the adoption of what works at scale.

With the aim of strengthening digital and AI literacy, especially among women and young people, countries should take practical steps to improve inclusion in the gig economy. These include partnering with training institutions and platforms to deliver market-relevant digital and green skills programmes; developing enabling policies, such as standardised contracting templates or minimum-information requirements that make platform work more transparent; and linking gig workers to social protection and financial services through simplified enrolment and contribution mechanisms. Partnerships between municipal governments, platforms, and MSMEs can also improve access to devices, affordable connectivity, and safe digital workspaces for underserved communities. These practical interventions

[33] The UNDP (2025) report "The Next Great Divergence: Why AI may Widen Inequality between Countries" provides a comprehensive discussion on actions needed to address the impact of AI on the economy and for human development.

help ensure that the gig economy becomes a pathway for decent work and upward mobility, rather than reinforcing existing inequalities.

Social protection

Ensuring social protection for the gig workers requires moving toward more inclusive and adaptable social protection systems by supporting the design and piloting of hybrid models that extend essential protections to gig workers without compromising the flexibility that attracts many to this form of work. Practical entry points include developing tailored micro-insurance schemes for health, accident, or income loss, and facilitating gig workers' enrolment in national health or social insurance programmes through subsidised premiums or simplified contribution mechanisms. In this connection, insights could be drawn from the hybrid social protection concept for gig workers by the Malaysia Digital Economy Corporation (MDEC) (Annex-1).

Portable benefits approaches are particularly relevant for fragmented work patterns, enabling workers to accumulate entitlements across multiple platforms and job types, provided that the design remains administratively simple and fiscally credible (Annex-1). Piloting such models in priority sectors, such as ride-hailing or delivery services, can demonstrate how small, task-linked contributions from platforms, workers, and governments can build meaningful protection over time. These mechanisms are especially important for highly mobile workers, enabling continuity of benefits regardless of how often they change gigs or combine multiple sources of income.

To sustain these systems, fiscal policy reforms will be essential. Progressive, gig-sensitive financing options should be identified, including earmarked digital levies, matched contributions, or platform-based transaction fees that channel resources directly into worker protection funds. By combining innovative benefit models with viable financing pathways, countries can build future-ready social protection systems that reduce precarity and support more resilient livelihoods in an increasingly platform-driven economy.

Gender Equality

Gig work presents new opportunities for women's economic participation in the Asia and the Pacific countries, but only if structural barriers related to access, safety, skills, and care responsibilities are deliberately addressed. As underscored in the UNDP Strategic Plan 2026–2029, gender equality must be treated not only as a goal but as an enabler of inclusive development outcomes. Gig work can be made more gender-inclusive by strengthening the enabling environment across three practical entry points. First, expanding women's access to digital infrastructure and skills, including targeted digital and AI-literacy programmes, device access initiatives, and partnerships with platforms to onboard women into higher-value digital work. Second, introducing gender-responsive safety and design standards, such as verified user identities, in-app safety tools, safer commuting options, and platform algorithms that increase visibility of women in higher-pay segments. Third, integrating care-sensitive measures, for example, childcare credits, flexible scheduling norms, or compensated downtime, into emerging gig-work frameworks, enabling women to participate without exacerbating existing care burdens.

Without such regulatory and programmatic action, existing gender inequalities will continue to restrict women's ability to benefit from the gig economy. By combining practical pilots with upstream policy reform, gig work should be transformed into a more meaningful pathway for women's empowerment and economic security. At the regional level, practical cooperation can include: sharing standards for safety-by-design on platforms, supporting regional initiatives to reduce the digital gender divide, and accelerating evidence-building on what improves women's outcomes across different gig segments.

Addressing green and digital transitions

The gig economy sits at the intersection of two major transitions shaping the Asia-Pacific: the rapid expansion of digital technologies and the accelerating shift toward greener economic systems. Countries need to leverage these transitions so that gig workers benefit from emerging opportunities rather than becoming casualties of technological or environmental shifts. A practical starting point for governments and platforms is to identify and scale new digital and AI-enabled gig roles, such as remote diagnostics for solar installations, climate data annotation, environmental monitoring, or last-mile green logistic that can expand livelihood options while contributing to national climate goals. It is also equally important to consider the environmental footprint of digitalisation and AI. Data centres, cloud services, and algorithmic processing consume significant energy and resources, contributing to emissions and e-waste. Excessive water use by the data centres may also exacerbate aridity (Ahmed, 2025).[34] UNDP's Asia and the Pacific Regional Programme Document 2026–2029, highlights that supporting inclusive green and digital transitions is

[34] Ahmed, Nazneen. 2025. Aridity in Asia-Pacific: A Silent Slow Burn, Rising Visible Losses. Blog. UNDP Asia and the Pacific. Published 8 December 2025.

central to building resilient economies and livelihoods. This includes fostering innovation in low-carbon solutions, promoting sustainable urbanization, and expanding access to digital technologies.

Countries need to embed gig-economy considerations into broader green growth and digital transformation strategies, ensuring that policies on renewable energy, circular economy, or urban mobility explicitly account for platform-mediated work. This may include supporting EV transitions for delivery and ride-hailing fleets, strengthening incentives for low-emission gig work, or integrating green-skills training into digital-skills programmes. Platforms can also be encouraged to adopt greener operational practices, including route optimisation, consolidated deliveries, and transparent emissions reporting. By aligning gig work with both digital and green transitions, governments can build future-ready labour markets that enhance economic resilience, reduce environmental impacts, and create new pathways for inclusive employment.

Adaptive Governance and Accountable Algorithms

Adaptive governance is essential for managing the profound shifts underway in the gig economy, where labour regulation, digital governance, fiscal policy, and social protection increasingly intersect. Governments need to build coherent, future-ready regulatory frameworks that respond to the unique dynamics of platform-mediated work. This includes advising on modern labour classifications, fair contract standards, and mechanisms that extend core protections to gig workers while preserving flexibility.

A critical element of this agenda is algorithmic accountability. Countries must develop proportionate regulatory requirements that oblige platforms to explain key algorithmic actions, publish high-level logic for task and pricing systems, and provide clear avenues for timely human review. However, this would require technical work on fairness metrics, algorithmic audit tools, data-governance safeguards, and worker-centred design principles to reduce information asymmetries and build more transparent and trusted digital labour markets.

Regional collaboration, including South-South cooperation, can enhance knowledge sharing and policy alignment. This, in turn, will promote cross-border cooperation, which is necessary to address the transnational nature of platforms, including shared standards for data protection, algorithmic fairness, and the prevention of illegal platform activities. Strengthening adaptive governance and accountable algorithms will therefore be essential to ensure that the gig economy develops in ways that advance rights, inclusion, and long-term human development across Asia and the Pacific.

8. Conclusion

Looking ahead, the gig economy in Asia and the Pacific region will be reshaped by rapid advances in automation, AI, and mobility technologies, requiring governments to prepare now for the next wave of labour market disruption. As discussed in detail in UNDP (2025), AI tools are increasingly capable of performing cognitive tasks traditionally done by online gig workers, from translation and transcription to basic content creation and entry-level coding. As these tools scale, a significant share of lower-skilled digital gigs may become automated, potentially reducing earnings opportunities for workers who depend on microtasks or entry-level freelance work. At the same time, emerging technologies such as autonomous vehicles could transform or even displace segments of ride-hailing and delivery work. The pace and distribution of these technological shifts are uneven, but the direction is clear: the nature of gig work will change dramatically, and policy frameworks will need to anticipate and respond to these transitions rather than react after the fact.

Equally important are the new forms of gig work emerging from the green and digital transitions. Demand is expected to grow for digitally enabled green jobs, from remote solar diagnostics and climate data annotation to last-mile green logistics, creating new entry points for workers if skills development and regulatory support keep pace. At the same time, the cross-border nature of digital gig platforms will raise complex policy questions around taxation, data governance, and competition. As more workers earn income from platforms headquartered abroad, governments will need new fiscal instruments and international coordination mechanisms to ensure fair taxation, protect workers' data rights, and prevent regulatory arbitrage. These future trends underscore the importance of anticipatory governance: building flexible, forward-looking regulatory systems that can evolve with technological change while safeguarding workers' rights, economic inclusion, and national development priorities.

The policy suggestions outlined in this paper reinforce a broader development agenda on economic transformation, social protection, digital governance, and innovation across Asia and the Pacific. As gig work is increasingly becoming a structural feature of labour markets in the region, it needs to be governed as part of a wider economic and social system. Strengthening social protection, advancing gender-responsive platform design, supporting green and digital transitions, enabling accountable algorithms, and modernising fiscal and governance frameworks- offer practical pathways for governments, platforms, worker organisations and partners in the region to begin addressing the risks and harnessing the opportunities of platform-mediated work.

Progress will depend on linking policy reform with implementable pilots, building multi-stakeholder coalitions, and developing coherent systems solutions across inclusive growth, digital, climate, and governance domains. Regional collaboration is needed to address cross-border platform dynamics and support shared learning on regulation, data protection, and portability of rights and benefits. Through proactive and system-wide actions, a collaborative partnership among government entities, multilateral organizations, bilateral partners, and the private sector can shape the gig economy in ways that expand opportunities, protect workers' rights, and support more inclusive, secure, and sustainable livelihoods for millions across Asia and the Pacific.

Annex-1:

Examples of Social Protection Models for the Gig Workers

A) MDEC Hybrid Social Protection Model[35] [36]

Malaysia Digital Economy Corporation (MDEC) pioneered a hybrid approach to support gig workers, through its eRezeki and Sharing Economy programme. It connects over 1.2 million Malaysians to digital freelancing opportunities and has generated RM 4 billion since 2016. MDEC's model combines flexible digital platforms with social protection measures; offers micro-insurance and optional access to national health and retirement schemes; promotes local cooperatives to reduce reliance on intermediaries.

B) Portable benefits model[37] [38]

Portable benefit refers to a social protection system that allows workers to carry their benefits with them across jobs and platforms, regardless of how often they switch employers, combine multiple gigs, or work on a part-time/intermittent basis. Instead of benefits being tied to a single employer, they are linked to the worker through an individual, often digital, account.

Under this model, contributions are pooled from multiple sources, such as platform companies, government, and workers themselves, and deposited into a worker's portable account whenever they complete a task or earn income. These contributions help build entitlements to health insurance, accident and injury protection, pensions, paid leave, unemployment support, or training funds. Because benefits accumulate even when workers move between platforms (e.g., food delivery one month, online freelancing the next), portable benefits reduce precarity and offer a fairer system for gig and informal workers. Since 2024, Central Provident Fund contributions have been made mandatory for platform workers under 30 in Singapore.[39]

C) Minimum Pay Floors

Minimum pay floors are regulatory or negotiated mechanisms that establish a baseline level of remuneration for gig workers, below which pay cannot fall. These floors may be defined as a minimum hourly earnings rate (accounting for both active working time and necessary waiting time) or as a minimum payment per completed task or trip. By setting a clear lower bound on earnings, minimum pay floors help reduce income volatility and counter downward pressure on wages driven by intense competition, opaque algorithmic pricing, and unilateral changes to platform pay structures.

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[35] TechNode Global. 2025. MDEC aims to push for 25.5 percent digital economy contribution to Malaysia's GDP by end-2025. Available at: https://technode.global/2025/02/19/mdec-aims-to-push-for-25-5-percent-digital-economy-contribution-to-malaysias-gdp-by-end-2025/ (accessed 15 November 2025).

[36] Malaysia Digital Economy Corporation (MDEC). n.d. Sharing economy. Available at: https://mdec.my/sharingeconomy (accessed 15 November 2025).

[37] Reader, Libby, Shelly Steward, and Natalie Foster. 2019. Designing Portable Benefits: A Resource Guide for Policymakers. Aspen Institute. Washington, DC.

[38] Schrag, Eli. 2025. Exploring portable benefits for gig workers: Key takeaways from a Brookings roundtable. Available at: https://www.brookings.edu/articles/exploring-portable-benefits-for-gig-workers/ (accessed 15 November 2025).

[39] Ministry of Manpower, Singapore. 2024. New Platform Workers Bill to strengthen protections for platform workers. Available at: https://www.mom.gov.sg/newsroom/press-releases/2024/0909-new-platform-workers-bill-to-strengthen-protections-for-platform-workers. (accessed 15 November 2025).

Annex-2:

Some Studies Suggesting Guidelines on Supporting Gig Economy Workers

Organization	Title	Issues Covered
UNDP[40]	The Next Great Divergence: Why AI may Widen Inequality between Countries	Examines AI from the perspective of the vulnerable, particularly its impact on human development in developing countries across the Asia-Pacific region.
APEC[41]	Guidelines on Providing Social Protection to Digital Platform Workers	Legal exclusion, financial barriers, representation, and inclusive social protection
ILO[42]	Exploring the Gig Economy: Challenges and Opportunities (booklet)	Types of gig work and what it looks like; • trade-offs between flexibility and job security; • skills demand and income levels; • how online platforms manage payments and contracts; • gig work as a potential stepping stone to the labour market; • impact of AI on gig work; • common challenges and online safety.
ILO & UNDP[43]	Emerging practices to improve access to and working conditions on digital labour platforms for refugees and host communities	Inclusive recruitment, fair contracts, minimum pay, and training for displaced and host communities; regulatory reforms recommended for flexible employment classification, access to finance, minimum wage standards, social protection, and collective bargaining rights.
World Bank[44]	Working Without Borders: The Promise and Peril of Online Gig Work	Social protection gaps, gender wage disparities, and youth employment
World Bank[45]	The Gig Economy and the Future of Work: Global Trends and Policy Directions	Employment classification, harmonizing labour policies, and social protection
OECD[46]	Gig Economy Platforms: Boon or Bane?	Employment trends, productivity, policy adaptation for gig platforms
UNDP[47]	Diversification of Employment in Latin America and the Caribbean	Gig work trends, resilience, social protection gaps (in Latin American countries)
UNDP[48]	Shaping the Future of Work through Digital Livelihoods	Digital skills, platform work, AI, gender, MSMEs

[40] https://www.undp.org/asia-pacific/publications/next-great-divergence (Accessed on 3 December 2025).
[41] https://unctad.org/meeting/first-meeting-informal-working-group-data-services-trade-and-development-policies (Accessed on 6 October 2025).
[42] https://www.ilo.org/publications/exploring-gig-economy-challenges-and-opportunities-booklet ((Accessed on 6 October 2025).
[43] https://www.undp.org/publications/emerging-practices-improve-access-and-working-conditions-digital-labour-platforms-refugees-and-host-communities (Accessed on 6 October 2025).
[44] https://openknowledge.worldbank.org/entities/publication/ebc4a7e2-85c6-467b-8713-e2d77e954c6c (Accessed on 6 October 2025).
[45] documents1.worldbank.org/curated/en/099060524074041161/pdf/P1796471e104d70c8193971d1ead6456d2e.pdf (Accessed on 6 October 2025).
[46] https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/gig-economy-platforms-boon-or-bane_fdb0570b-en.html (Accessed on 6 October 2025).
[47] https://www.undp.org/latin-america/publications/diversification-employment-latin-america-and-caribbean-gig-employment-and-implications-economic-resilience (Accessed on 6 October 2025).
[48] https://www.undp.org/sites/g/files/zskgke326/files/2025-09/future_of_work_eng.pdf (Accessed on 6 October 2025).